

Word family: **progress / progresses / progressed / progressing / progressive / progressively / progression**

Base word: progress

Forms: progresses, progressed, progressing

Related forms: progressive, progressively, progression

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞) / related adjective and adverb forms (相關形容詞及副詞)

Your sentence:

> “It seems to ask big questions about **progress**, belief, and civilisation...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **progress** means **the process of moving forward or improving over time, especially in human society, knowledge, technology, or civilisation**.

繁體中文： **進步；發展；逐步變得更先進、更完善或更接近某個理想狀態的過程**

中文翻譯：

> “It seems to ask big questions about **progress**, belief, and civilisation...”

「它似乎會提出一些關於**進步 / 發展**、信念和文明的大問題。」

Here:

progress = 人類社會、知識、科技或文明是否真的在隨時間向前發展 / 改善

1. **progress = improvement or forward development (進步) — 進步；發展**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: Gradual improvement or development toward a better, more advanced, or more complete state.

Practice 1 — Original

> “The book asks difficult questions about human **progress**.”

「這本書提出了一些關於人類**進步**的難題。」

Practice 2

> “Technology has brought enormous **progress** in medicine.”

「科技為醫學帶來了巨大的**進步**。」

Practice 3

> “The country has made significant **progress** in education.”

「這個國家在教育方面取得了顯著**進展**。」

progress = 某人、社會、知識或系統逐步改善、發展或變得更先進

Common:

- * make progress
- * significant progress
- * scientific progress
- * technological progress
- * social progress

2. **progress** = movement toward a goal or completion (進展) — 進展 ; 進度

Progress can mean how far a task, project, process, recovery, or journey has advanced toward completion.

Practice 4

> “We are making good **progress** on the project.”

「我們在這個項目上的**進展**很好。」

Practice 5

> “The teacher checked the students’ **progress**.”

「老師檢查了學生的**學習進度 / 進展**。」

progress = 某件事朝目標、完成或預期結果推進到甚麼程度

This is closely related to Meaning 1, but the focus is on **advancement toward a specific endpoint**, not general improvement.

For learner use, it is useful to show separately.

3. **progress** = move forward / advance (動詞) — 進展；向前推進

As a verb, **progress** means to move forward or develop toward a later stage.

Practice 6

> “The work is **progressing** well.”

「工作**進展**順利。」

Practice 7

> “As the course **progressed**, the material became more difficult.”

「隨着課程**逐步進行**，內容變得更困難。」

progress = 某項活動、工作、事件或過程逐步向前發展

This is the verb counterpart of the noun senses.

4. **progress** = move to a later stage/level (階段) — 晉級；進入下一階段

Progress can mean advancing to the next stage in a competition, course, process, career, etc.

Practice 8

> “Only the top teams will **progress** to the next round.”

「只有排名最高的隊伍可以**晉級**下一輪。」

Practice 9

> “Students must pass the test before they can **progress** to the next level.”

「學生必須先通過測驗，才能**升到 / 進入**下一級。」

progress to something = 進入下一個階段、級別或步驟

This develops from the broader “move forward” sense and does not need a separate core category.

5. **progress = become more advanced or more serious over time (情況發展) — 發展 ; 惡化 / 演變**

A disease, situation, or process can **progress** as it moves into later stages.

Practice 10

> “The disease **progressed** rapidly.”

「病情迅速**惡化 / 發展**。」

Practice 11

> “The situation **progressed** from disagreement to open conflict.”

「情況從分歧逐步**演變**成公開衝突。」

****progress = 某種情況、疾病或過程逐步進入更後面的階段****

Important: **progress** does not always mean “become better.”

A disease can **progress**, meaning it becomes more advanced or serious.

This distinction is very important.

6. **progress = physical forward movement through space (較少見) — 前進 ; 推進**

In formal or descriptive use, **progress** can refer to physical movement forward.

Practice 12

> “The hikers made slow **progress** through the snow.”

「行山人士在雪地中緩慢**前進**。」

Practice 13

> “The vehicle could make little **progress** on the muddy road.”

「車輛在泥濘道路上幾乎無法**向前推進**。」

****progress = 實際在空間中向前移動****

This is a legitimate modern use, though less central than the abstract senses.

Related form: **progressive**

Progressive has several important meanings.

progressive = developing gradually (逐步的) — 漸進的 ; 逐步的

Practice 14

> “The patient showed **progressive** improvement.”

「病人的情況出現**逐步改善**。」

progressive = 一步一步發展或改變的

progressive = favouring change/reform (改革性的) — 進步的 ; 改革取向的

In social or institutional contexts, **progressive** can describe ideas, policies, or approaches that favour reform or change.

Practice 15

> “The school introduced a more **progressive** teaching approach.”

「學校引入了一種較**進步 / 改革取向**的教學方式。」

This word can also have political meanings in some contexts, so interpretation depends heavily on context.

Related form: **progressively**

Progressively means gradually, increasingly, or step by step.

Practice 16

> “The exercises become **progressively** harder.”

「這些練習會**逐漸**變得更難。」

Practice 17

> “The weather became **progressively** worse.”

「天氣**逐步**變差。」

progressively = 隨時間或階段逐漸地、一步一步地

Related form: **progression**

Progression means a sequence or gradual movement from one stage to another.

Practice 18

> “The course follows a logical **progression** from basic to advanced topics.”

「這門課程按照由基礎到進階的邏輯**進程 / 順序**安排。」

Practice 19

> “Doctors monitored the **progression** of the disease.”

「醫生監察疾病的**發展 / 惡化進程**。」

progression = 從一個階段逐步發展到下一階段的過程或順序

Important distinction: **progress vs improvement**

improvement

means becoming better.

progress

means moving forward toward a later, more complete, or more advanced stage.

Usually:

> progress = positive

But not always.

For example:

> “The disease progressed.”

does not mean:

> “The disease improved.”

It means the disease advanced to a later stage.

Important distinction: **progress vs development**

development

is broader and can mean growth, change, creation, or formation.

progress

usually emphasizes forward movement toward a goal or a more advanced state.

> human development

> human progress

The first is broader; the second often implies advancement or improvement.

Important distinction: **progress vs advance**

advance

can be noun or verb and often means movement forward in position, knowledge, technology, etc.

progress

often emphasizes a gradual process over time.

> technological advances

> technological progress

Very close, but **advance** can refer more easily to a specific breakthrough:

> a major medical advance

whereas **progress** often describes the broader ongoing process.

Important distinction: **progress vs achievement**

achievement

is a completed success or accomplishment.

progress

is movement toward success or completion.

> progress toward a goal

> achieve the goal

So progress may exist even before the final result is reached.

Important distinction: **progress vs process**

These look similar but are different.

process

= a series of actions/stages

progress

= advancement through those stages or toward a goal

> learning process

> learning progress

Grammar note: **progress is usually uncountable**

This is very important.

Natural:

> "We made good progress."

Not normally:

> “We made a good progress.” ❌

Natural:

> “There has been a lot of progress.”

Not:

> “There have been many progresses.” ❌ in ordinary modern English

So:

****progress = usually uncountable noun****

Useful construction: ****make progress — 取得進展****

Practice 20

> “She is making good ****progress**** in English.”

「她的英文正在取得很好的****進步 / 進展****。」

Practice 21

> “We made little ****progress**** today.”

「我們今天幾乎沒有取得甚麼****進展****。」

This is one of the most important collocations.

Not normally:

> do progress ❌

Use:

> make progress ✅

Useful construction: ****in progress — 正在進行中****

Practice 22

> “The meeting is currently in **progress**.”

「會議目前**正在進行中**。」

Practice 23

> “Construction work is still in **progress**.”

「建築工程仍然**在進行中**。」

in progress = 某件事已開始，但尚未完成

This is a highly useful fixed expression.

Useful construction: **progress toward/towards** — 朝.....取得進展

Practice 24

> “The team has made progress toward its goal.”

「團隊正朝目標取得**進展**。」

This belongs to the advancement-toward-goal sense.

Pronunciation note

There is a common pronunciation difference in some varieties of English:

Noun

PROgress

Verb

proGRESS

This distinction is especially common in American English, though pronunciation patterns vary by accent.

It is useful for learners because the spelling stays the same while the stress may shift.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **progress**
* **progresses**
* **progressed**
* **progressing**
* **progressive**
* **progressively**
* **progression**

The main curation issue is that many contexts—education, projects, civilisation, recovery, journeys—share the same broad idea of **forward movement through stages** and should not be split merely because the object changes.

At the same time, the disease use is worth explicitly teaching because **progress** there does not imply improvement.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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progress — improvement/development	朝更先進、更完善或更理想的狀態逐步發展；進步
progress — advancement toward goal	某項工作、學習或過程朝完成 / 目標推進的程度；進展
progress — verb	逐步向前發展、進行或進入下一階段
progress — disease/situation	某種病情或情況逐步發展到更後期；不一定表示改善
progress — physical movement	在空間中向前推進；較低頻
progressive	漸進的；逐步發展的；某些語境下可指改革取向的
progressively	逐漸地；一步一步地
progression	從一個階段逐步進入下一階段的發展過程

For your original sentence

> “It seems to ask big questions about **progress**, belief, and civilisation...”

The exact meaning is:

progress = 人類文明、社會、科技和知識是否真的在隨時間變得更先進或更好

So:

> **questions about progress**

= **關於「人類進步究竟是甚麼、是否真的在進步」這類宏觀問題**

For your database, I would count **3 genuinely useful core meanings** for **progress**:

1. **improvement or forward development**
2. **advancement toward a goal/completion**
3. **verb — move through later stages, including disease/situation progression**

I would treat physical forward movement as a lower-priority extension of #2/#3, keep **in progress** as a fixed construction, and keep **progressive / progressively / progression** as family extensions rather than inflate the base count.